

KEEPING THE COVENANT

Some thoughts on Christian Education

David M. Blunt

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"Give ear, O my people, to my law; incline your ears to the words of my mouth.

2 I will open my mouth in a parable: I will utter dark sayings of old:

3 Which we have heard and known, and our fathers have told us.

4 We will not hide them from their children, shewing to the generation to come the praises of the LORD, and his strength, and his wonderful works that he hath done.

5 For he established a testimony in Jacob, and appointed a law in Israel, which he commanded our fathers, that they should make them known to their children:

6 That the generation to come might know them, even the children which should be born; who should arise and declare them to their children:

7 That they might set their hope in God, and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments:

8 And might not be as their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation; a generation that set not their heart aright, and whose spirit was not stedfast with God.

9 The children of Ephraim, being armed, and carrying bows, turned back in the day of battle.

10 They kept not the covenant of God, and refused to walk in his law;

11 And forgot his works, and his wonders that he had shewed them."

- PSALM 78:1-11.

Purpose of Education

Education has been defined as "training for independent life." Man is surely unique among the creatures in that such a large proportion of his existence is taken up with the development necessary for independent activity in the world. If he lives for threescore years and ten, then fully one quarter of that lifespan will likely have been

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lived in the parental home. There a life which began in complete dependence upon others is fitted for independence: an individual growing physically and mentally develops knowledge and skills and absorbs a culture; his whole life is shaped for the future. He learns not so much by instinct but by instruction and example. Education is therefore of great importance.

We must go beyond this however. Man is not only related to the world, but also to God. He is of the earth, earthy, but he is also a living soul. And this is the more fundamental relationship: Adam lived unto God before any human society existed, and men continue to be accountable to their Maker even when they leave this world behind. Therefore any education worthy of the name must take cognisance of this fact: that human beings have also eternal souls, which are developing for eternity.

Here we notice a crucial thing: the situation of man now is the direct opposite of what was the case before the Fall. Our first parents came into the world as independent adults, requiring no process of training: they were possessed of an intuitive knowledge of God and of His will, by virtue of their souls being made after His image in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness. And their spirits leaned in dependency upon God. Since the Fall into sin, when that image was lost, men and women arrive in the world as helpless babes needing to be weaned, and, most tragic of all, as rebels from God by nature. A proper training therefore will have these two aims: to prepare such an individual for independent life in the world, and for dependent life in relation to God. And the latter must be the true foundation for success in the former.

Philosophy of Education

Probably most educational approaches today fall into either of two categories:-

1) *those that stress that education should serve the needs of the individual.* The emphasis here is generally upon intellectual development. It is agreed that each generation must build upon the work of the preceeding one, particularly in the fields of science and technology, and therefore the ablest minds especially should be encouraged. Schooling is often ordered so that the brightest children may make the fastest progress, yet others stress that every individual must be given the opportunity to reach his or her full learning potential. This approach is generally the preserve of the middle and upper classes.

2) *those that stress that education should serve the needs of society.* Individuals function as elements in a wider society, and so other educational philosophies give weight to the development of personal character. In former generations the virtues of hard work, duty to superiors and loyalty to country were impressed upon the masses in order to produce an obedient workforce and fighting force. With the rise

of secular humanism, education has become a vital tool in large-scale attempts at social engineering: the ideal society posited by atheists and agnostics of every hue will be created as children are taught from the cradle onwards to forego any idea of moral absolutes and to abandon any sense of discrimination.

Against these alternatives there is a third: that is, *that education should serve the "needs" or requirements of God*. His purpose is to glorify Himself, and therefore our chief end must be to glorify Him, also in education as well as in the rest of our existence. Education too must begin and end with the glory of God. We may only glorify God by our loving obedience to His revealed will. We are bound to ask then, what are God's requirements for education? Surely He has not left us to our own imaginations in a matter we have seen to be so significant?!

CHRIST-CENTRED

The title of Psalm 78 is "Maschil of Asaph": "A Psalm for Asaph to give instruction", according to the margin. Teaching about teaching. And the first thing we encounter is the Teacher. The speaker in verses 1&2 can only be God Himself: who else may address us with such authority, demanding our attention? Later revelation makes clear that it is the Lord Jesus Christ who is the mouth of God. In the midst of the seven illustrations of the kingdom of heaven in Matthew 13, we read:

"All these things spake Jesus unto the multitude in parables; and without a parable spake he not unto them: That it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophet, saying, I will open my mouth in parables; I will utter things which have been kept secret from the foundation of the world." (MATT. 13:34,35).

The Son of God was appointed the Mediator between God and men from all eternity. Under the Old Testament He revealed God's will by His Spirit in the prophets. On assuming our flesh He was seen to be "full of grace and truth" (JOHN 1:14) and people who heard His teaching were astonished at His wisdom (MATT. 13:54), convinced that He was a teacher come from God (JOHN 3:2), the true Prophet. He assumed to Himself the title Rabbi (MATT. 23:10) which the Jews used to address their teachers.

What relevance does this have to education generally? The Bible states that Christ is the centre of all true knowledge. "And he is before all things, and by him all things consist." (COL. 1:17). The whole created order is constituted in Him, the universe upheld by Him. He is as the hub of the wheel from which all the spokes go outward. He alone integrates the creation, making harmonious sense of all its aspects and diversities. Christ is also the circumference of all true knowledge. "In whom are hid all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge." (COL. 2:3). The boundary of what is wholesome for man to know is framed by Him. All truth is God's truth: outside of Christ we are eating the forbidden fruit.

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The point is that education must begin, proceed and end by giving us answers to the most basic questions of our existence: who am I? where am I from? what is my purpose? where am I going? Without answers to these questions, all education is ultimately vain and meaningless: it has failed in its object to properly prepare us for life in its fullest sense. But these questions are all answered in Christ, the “Alpha and Omega, the beginning and the end, the first and the last.” (REV. 22:13). Only in knowing Him do we really know anything at all.

In verse 3 of Psalm 78 the speaker changes: Asaph refers to the means by which the Word of God in Christ is conveyed to God’s people: “our fathers have told us.” The word delivered through prophets was later inscripturated or committed wholly to writing, such that the Holy Scriptures are “the words of (his) mouth.” That word was read by father to son, from generation to generation. To say then that education should be Christ-centred is also to say that it should be Bible-based, for the Scriptures are now His mouth.

Such a philosophy of education sounds revolutionary to the majority of the Lord’s professing people today! The parable of the wise and foolish builders comes to mind. In this world we are each building our lives for eternity: every true Christian will agree that salvation is received only as our lives are founded upon the Rock Christ Jesus; “justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus” (ROM. 3:24). But the principle so tenaciously held with respect to justification is neglected when it comes to sanctification! Not every area of my life need be grounded in Christ! In leisure, politics, economics, etc., and education the Lord has left us to our own devices. It is as though the believer begins with a house built on rock, but then may erect extensions as he pleases - which in fact rest on sand! But has he “planning permission” for this?

Such “pietism” is in fact nothing other than a flat denial that education is one of the “good works” for which the man of God is prepared by the inspired Scriptures (2 TIM. 3:16,17).

COMPREHENSIVE

I refer here not to a system but to the scope of Christian education. What exactly is to be taught to children? The Psalmist was resolved to instruct the succeeding generation in the three broad categories of knowledge (v.4) which encompass all true knowledge:

a) “the praises of the Lord.” God’s being and attributes must be taught: children need to learn that God IS, and that God is GOD. The contemplation of God is the highest study of all. He is the alone explanation of all else that is. All true learn-